

SENATE JOINT RESOLUTION 1188

By Yager

A RESOLUTION to honor and commend Rhett Pratt for his service to the General Assembly.

WHEREAS, it is appropriate that the members of this General Assembly should pause to pay tribute to those estimable legislative employees whose commitment to excellence, genuine decency, and dedication to public service have brought untold benefits to the citizens of the State of Tennessee; and

WHEREAS, Rhett Pratt is precisely such an individual, having served the Tennessee General Assembly with distinction, dedication, and an unmistakably jovial disposition for more than a decade; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Pratt earned a Bachelor of Arts degree in Political Science with a concentration in Public Administration and a master's degree in public policy and administration from the University of Tennessee, Knoxville, an institution to which he has remained devoted with the kind of loyalty only a true, long-suffering Volunteers fan could sustain; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Pratt began his legislative career as an assistant for Senator Steve Dickerson in May 2014 and served in that role until 2019; and

WHEREAS, from his role as legislative assistant, Mr. Pratt then joined the Senate State and Local Government Committee as a research analyst in 2019, reviewing calendars, preparing analyses, and providing legislative guidance in committee meetings, all while gently redirecting any lobbyist who sought an audience with him to the more orderly venue of his email inbox; and

WHEREAS, from 2021 to 2023, Rhett Pratt gained invaluable experience during his time as a legislative budget analyst within the Office of Legislative Budget, in which position he

conducted a thorough analysis of state budgets in the fields of education, higher education, and capital projects; and

WHEREAS, from January to October of 2023, he briefly departed the General Assembly for "the dark side," devoting his time and talents to government relations at the Tennessee Municipal League, where he advocated for municipal interests in the areas of finance and property while further cementing his undying love for all things pertaining to the riveting study of municipal governance; and

WHEREAS, in October of 2023, Mr. Pratt returned to the General Assembly as the senior legislative advisor for the Senate Republican Caucus Chairman Ken Yager, in which position he researched key issues, analyzed legislation, and prepared reports for Chairman Yager and the Caucus; and

WHEREAS, Rhett Pratt has since returned to the dark side, now serving his beloved Tennessee Municipal League with acumen and alacrity as Senior Director of Government Relations and Membership Engagement, earning the respect of his colleagues and community alike; and

WHEREAS, the Tennessee Municipal League's gain is, truly, the General Assembly's loss; and

WHEREAS, no stranger to awards, Mr. Pratt earned the well-deserved distinction of being named the 2020 Senate Employee of the Year in recognition of his years of conscientious and devoted service; and

WHEREAS, his professional accomplishments aside, Mr. Pratt is quick to credit the love and support of his wife, Jocelyn, as the true measure of his good fortune; and

WHEREAS, a true son of the Senate, his fiscal discipline is perhaps best evidenced by his measured decision to graduate to a more expensive brand of cigarettes only after securing a corresponding salary increase; and

WHEREAS, consistent with that same fiscal philosophy, his subsequent decision to quit smoking is understood to have been informed, in part, by health concerns, though the annual expenditure is said to have weighed rather more heavily; and

WHEREAS, beyond the briefing books and budget analyses, Rhett is equally well known for an affable manner, a remarkably steady supply of groan-worthy puns, and a gift for lifting the mood of any room he walks into; and

WHEREAS, for all that levity, his colleagues have learned to recognize the phrase "cards on the table" as the unmistakable signal that Mr. Pratt is setting the jokes aside and getting down to brass tacks; and

WHEREAS, he possesses a near-mythical tolerance for spicy foods, apparently finding delight in heat levels that would send the rest of us in search of a glass of milk; and

WHEREAS, his devotion to the University of Tennessee Volunteers and the Nashville Predators is exceeded only, perhaps, by his loyalty to Taco Bell; and

WHEREAS, his attention to detail and coordination extends even to yard work, as he is known to keep a shirt reserved exclusively for mowing the grass, selected for its precise color match to his mower; and

WHEREAS, his generosity is perhaps most quietly demonstrated in his consistent and personal kindness toward those in Nashville who are down on their luck, an instinct he extends without fanfare or expectation of notice; and

WHEREAS, he possesses a singular and well-documented ability to convert what should be a fifteen-minute drive into something closer to thirty; and

WHEREAS, through every ebb and flow this profession offers, Rhett has maintained a genuinely remarkable outlook, one that finds the bright side of nearly any situation and brings the people around him along for the ride; and

WHEREAS, Rhett is fondly remembered by those around him for his jolly humming, his enthusiastic renditions of "Purple Rain," his unhurried approach to the posted speed limit, his gift for routinizing, and his annual stewardship of the office college football pick 'em; and

WHEREAS, regarded by his colleagues as one of the kindest and most decent people ever to walk the halls of this Capitol, Rhett Pratt has distinguished himself as a public servant of the highest order and is richly deserving of the respect, admiration, and commendation of this General Assembly; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE SENATE OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES CONCURRING, that we honor Rhett Pratt for his meritorious service to the General Assembly and extend to him our heartfelt wishes for every continued success in his career with the Tennessee Municipal League.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.